

The Boring- Automation Agency

The unglamorous workflows small companies
pay to never think about.

THE GAP

\$5B

Zapier is worth about five billion dollars for one boring job: moving data between apps that don't talk to each other. The solo version reportedly pays \$500–5,000 a month per client.

Reported bands, agency guides. Hold loosely.

THE THESIS

You build the plumbing.

CRM ✕ invoicing. Form ✕ inbox. Sheet ✕ Slack. You wire the tools together on n8n or Make, drop an AI node in for the messy parts, and charge a retainer to keep it running.

WHY ONE PERSON NOW

~80%

The plumbing became drag-and-drop. At Lovingly, a few workflows automated about 80% of a team's data-shuffling busywork. The hours that came back were the entire point.

Operator experience.

THE EVIDENCE

\$310M

Zapier's revenue at a ~\$5B valuation, on about \$1.4M raised. n8n raised at \$2.5B with 3,000+ enterprise customers. The whole iPaaS market: est. \$14–23B in 2026.

Zapier/n8n – reported & verified.

THE STACK

< \$100/mo

n8n or Make, plus a Claude or GPT node for the messy inputs. The client pays for their own apps. Your cost is the platform and your time. That is the whole margin.

Public tool pricing.

THE HONEST MATH

\$2–6K/mo

Realistic year one, from 3–6 retainer clients, once past a slow first month. Three ways it fails: platform risk, commoditization, and the one nobody automates, distribution.

Estimate, not audited. Not a promise.

THE BLUEPRINT

Free. Every source flagged.

The niche picker, the first workflow, the retainer pricing sheet, the failure modes, and the sources with confidence flags. The full breakdown is in the episode.

theoperatoreconomy.com